



RL.7.3

How Story Elements Interact

Grade 7
ELA

Vocabulary • Task Cards • Guided Practice • Independent Work • Exit Ticket



Key Words & Definitions

Slide 2

Analyze

To examine the parts of something closely to understand how it works as a whole.

Example: We analyze how Maya's fear changes her choices during the storm.



Drama

A story written to be performed on stage, told mostly through dialogue and stage directions.

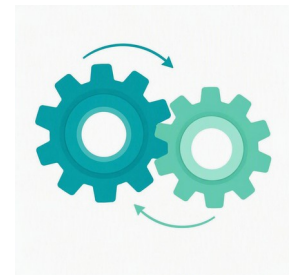
Example: In the drama, the stage directions show the brothers standing apart.



Interact

To act on one another; when one element affects or changes another.

Example: The setting and character interact when the blizzard forces Sam to turn back.





Key Words & Definitions

Slide 3

Character

The people or figures in a story whose traits and choices drive the action.

Example: Jonah's stubbornness keeps him from asking for help.



Setting

The time and place of a story, including weather, culture, and mood.

Example: The setting of a flooded town limits where the family can go.



Plot

The sequence of events, including conflict, rising action, climax, and resolution.

Example: The plot turns when the letter is finally opened.





Task Card 1: The Locked Gate

Read & Answer

SHORT STORY

Every morning Nadia cut through the community garden on her way to school. She knew the path by heart: past the tomato cages, around the compost bins, out the back gate onto Delmar Street. It saved her nine minutes, and nine minutes was the difference between walking and running.

On Tuesday the gate was chained shut. A laminated sign hung from the links: CLOSED FOR REPAIRS — SEPT 14–19. Nadia checked her watch. 7:38. Going around meant six extra blocks and a light at Delmar that took forever.

The fence beside the gate was low, low enough that a boy from her homeroom had cleared it last spring while everyone laughed. Nadia stared at it for a long moment. Then she thought about the promise she had made to her coach after the third late slip: never again. She turned, shifted her backpack higher on her shoulders, and started running the long way.

She came through the classroom door at 7:47 with her lungs burning and her hair stuck to her forehead. The bell rang three seconds later. She was on time.

1

How does the setting (the locked gate) affect Nadia's actions?

- A. It makes her give up on going to school.
- B. It forces her to choose a longer route and run.
- C. It causes her to argue with her coach.
- D. It convinces her to climb the fence.

2

Which character trait is revealed by Nadia's choice?

- A. Carelessness
- B. Dishonesty
- C. Responsibility
- D. Shyness



Answer Key — Task Card 1

Check Your Work

1

How does the setting (the locked gate) affect Nadia's actions?

B — The closed gate (setting) changes her route and pushes her to run.

2

Which character trait is revealed by Nadia's choice?

C — Keeping her promise to her coach shows responsibility.

Correct answers: B • C



Task Card 2: The Last Seat

Read & Answer

SHORT STORY

The bus was full except for one seat, and that seat was beside Marcus. He was sitting against the window with his hood up, and he had not spoken to anyone since Friday, when his pass in the final seconds had been picked off and the season had ended in the mud.

Tia hesitated in the aisle while the driver waited. She could stand for twenty minutes and hold the rail, or she could sit down. Two rows back, someone coughed impatiently. She sat.

For five minutes neither of them said anything. The bus turned onto Third, then Ridge. Marcus kept his eyes on the glass. Tia opened her book, read the same paragraph three times, and closed it again.

"That pass in the third quarter," she finally said, not looking at him. "The one across the middle. That was unreal."

Marcus didn't answer right away. Then his shoulders came down half an inch, and he almost smiled. "It was supposed to go to Ellis."

"It went better."

By the time the bus reached her stop, Marcus had pushed his hood back and was arguing about who should play free safety next season.

1

How do the two characters interact to move the plot forward?

- A. Tia's comment opens Marcus up and changes the mood.
- B. Marcus refuses to speak for the whole ride.
- C. Tia decides to stand instead of sitting.
- D. The bus driver settles their argument.

2

How does the crowded bus (setting) shape the events?

- A. It hides Marcus from Tia.
- B. It ends the conversation early.
- C. It leaves only one seat, forcing them together.
- D. It makes them miss their stop.



Answer Key — Task Card 2

Check Your Work

1

How do the two characters interact to move the plot forward?

A — Her compliment shifts Marcus from silence to hope.

2

How does the crowded bus (setting) shape the events?

C — With one seat left, the setting forces the interaction.

Correct answers: A • C



Task Card 3: Stage Directions

Read & Answer

SHORT STORY

[A kitchen, evening. Rain streaks the window over the sink. A newspaper is spread across the table. FATHER sits behind it. The back door opens and LENA enters, coat dripping, holding a large envelope she has tucked inside her jacket to keep dry.]

LENA: It came.

FATHER: [not looking up, turning a page] Mm.

LENA: [taking off her coat slowly, watching him] Dad. It came.

[A pause. Rain. FATHER lowers the newspaper an inch, then all the way. He folds it once, sets it on the table, and squares the edges with both hands.]

FATHER: From the university.

LENA: From the university.

[FATHER stands. He crosses to the sink, looks out at the rain, then turns back to her.]

FATHER: You've been carrying that around all afternoon, haven't you.

LENA: [quietly] Since two o'clock.

FATHER: [after a beat, gently] Then open it.

1

What do the stage directions reveal about the father?

- A. He is disappointed in Lena.
- B. His attention shifts from distracted to fully focused.
- C. He already knows what the letter says.
- D. He is angry about the rain.

2

How does the dialogue build tension in this drama?

- A. Lena repeats herself until her father reacts.
- B. The father tells a long story.
- C. The characters describe the setting in detail.
- D. Lena leaves the room without speaking.



Answer Key — Task Card 3

Check Your Work

1

What do the stage directions reveal about the father?

B — Lowering the paper and standing shows growing attention.

2

How does the dialogue build tension in this drama?

A — Her repetition forces the father to respond, raising tension.

Correct answers: B • A



Task Card 4: The Power Outage

Read & Answer

SHORT STORY

The lights went out during the third act of the school play. Not a flicker — everything at once: the stage lamps, the exit signs humming above the doors, the little red light on the sound board. The auditorium went completely black, and for two full seconds nobody made a sound.

Then somebody in the wings whispered, "What do we do?" and half the cast froze exactly where they stood. Priya, who had carried three scenes by herself, stopped mid-line. The audience began to murmur.

Devon had one line in the entire show. He played a messenger in scene two, said eleven words, and spent the rest of the play holding a lantern in the back. In the dark, he walked downstage — counting his steps, because he had watched the blocking every night for six weeks — and started speaking Priya's next line, loud and steady, from memory.

Someone in the third row turned on a phone flashlight. Then another, and another, until the stage was lit in pale, shaky white. The audience laughed, then leaned in. Priya found her place and answered him. When the power came back four minutes later, the cast picked up exactly where Devon had carried them.

1

How does the plot event (the outage) reveal Devon's character?

- A. It shows he memorized only his own line.
- B. It shows he panics under pressure.
- C. It shows he is calm and takes initiative.
- D. It shows he prefers being offstage.

2

What is the effect of the outage on the plot?

- A. It ends the play early.
- B. It creates a problem that changes who leads the scene.
- C. It causes the audience to leave.
- D. It removes the conflict from the story.



Answer Key — Task Card 4

Check Your Work

1

How does the plot event (the outage) reveal Devon's character?

C — He steps forward and keeps going, showing calm initiative.

2

What is the effect of the outage on the plot?

B — The problem shifts leadership of the scene to Devon.

Correct answers: C • B



Task Card 5: Low Tide

Read & Answer

SHORT STORY

Grandpa said the clams were best at low tide, so Ren set his alarm for 4:30 a.m. and regretted it the instant it went off. The truck smelled like coffee and rubber boots. Nobody talked on the drive out.

The beach was gray and far colder than Ren expected. Wind came off the water in flat sheets, and the wet sand pulled at his boots with every step. Grandpa handed him a rake and a bucket, showed him where the little airholes dimpled the flats, and said, "Dig where it breathes."

For an hour, Ren's bucket stayed empty. His fingers went numb. He dug too shallow, then too fast, then in the wrong place entirely. Beside him, his grandfather worked in the same slow rhythm he had kept since they arrived — set, pull, sift, step — without complaining once, without checking the sky.

Just before sunrise, Ren's rake struck something hard. He dug with his hands and came up with a clam the size of his palm. Then another. Then four more from the same patch.

By seven the bucket was half full and the sun had turned the flats orange. Ren looked over at his grandfather, seventy-two years old, still bent to the sand, and finally understood why the man still woke up before the tide.

1

How does the setting affect what the characters must do?

- A. The tide and early hour force them to wake and work in the cold.
- B. The beach makes clamming impossible.
- C. The sunrise ends their search.
- D. The weather causes them to go home.

2

What change in Ren does the story's ending show?

- A. He decides clamming is a waste of time.
- B. He grows impatient with his grandfather.
- C. He comes to understand his grandfather's patience.
- D. He asks to sleep in the next day.



Answer Key — Task Card 5

Check Your Work

1

How does the setting affect what the characters must do?

A — Low tide at dawn dictates the timing and conditions.

2

What change in Ren does the story's ending show?

C — The ending shows new understanding of his grandfather.

Correct answers: A • C



Task Card 6: The Substitute

Read & Answer

SHORT STORY

When Mr. Alvarez was out, the class treated it like a holiday. It had happened twice before, and both times the room had come apart within ten minutes. This time the substitute was new — young, with a folder of instructions she kept checking and a name none of them bothered to learn.

By 9:05 a paper airplane crossed the room. By 9:07 there were three. Somebody in the back was playing a video out loud. Jamal, who usually joined in and was usually the one folding the airplanes, was reaching for a sheet of notebook paper when he happened to look up.

The substitute was writing the date on the board. Her handwriting was small and careful, and her hand was shaking. She wrote the date twice because the first one came out crooked, and she did not turn around.

Jamal put the paper down. He picked up a stray airplane from the floor beside his desk, dropped it in the recycling bin, sat back down, and opened his book to page 112.

The girl next to him noticed. Then the boy behind her. Within a minute the video stopped, the airplanes stopped, and the room was quiet enough to hear the clock. The substitute finished the date, set down the marker, and her shoulders dropped an inch before she turned around.

1

How does one character's action change the other characters?

- A. Jamal's quiet choice spreads and settles the class.
- B. The substitute shouts to gain control.
- C. Mr. Alvarez returns and stops the noise.
- D. The students continue throwing airplanes.

2

What does the substitute's shaking hands suggest?

- A. She is cold.
- B. She is nervous and struggling.
- C. She is excited to teach.
- D. She is writing quickly.



Answer Key — Task Card 6

Check Your Work

1

How does one character's action change the other characters?

A — His action is copied and changes the room's behavior.

2

What does the substitute's shaking hands suggest?

B — The detail reveals her nervousness, which motivates Jamal.

Correct answers: A • B



Teacher-Led Practice (1–3)

Guided • 6 Q's

1

Analyzing how elements interact means studying how they —

- A. appear in a glossary
- B. affect and change one another
- C. are spelled correctly
- D. are listed in order

3

A blizzard traps a family indoors for three days. This is an example of —

- A. setting shaping plot
- B. plot shaping vocabulary
- C. theme shaping setting
- D. character shaping genre

2

In a drama, stage directions mainly help readers understand —

- A. the author's biography
- B. how characters move and speak
- C. the page numbers
- D. the book's title



Teacher-Led Practice (4–6)

Guided • 6 Q's

4

A character who lies in chapter one and confesses in chapter ten shows —

- A. a static setting
- B. character change across the plot
- C. an unreliable narrator
- D. a flashback

6

Two friends argue, and one moves away. This interaction most directly creates —

- A. a setting
- B. a conflict that drives the plot
- C. a definition
- D. a stage direction

5

Which question best analyzes character-plot interaction?

- A. How many pages are in the chapter?
- B. Where does the story take place first?
- C. How does the character's decision cause the next event?
- D. Who published the story?



Answer Key — Teacher-Led Practice

6 Questions

1

B — Interaction means elements affect and change one another.

2

B — Stage directions show movement, tone, and action.

3

A — The blizzard (setting) creates the plot's situation.

4

B — The confession shows character change over the plot.

5

C — It links a character's decision to the next event.

6

B — The argument creates conflict that drives the plot.



Independent Practice (1–2)

Independent • 8 Q's

- 1 The best evidence for analyzing character is —
- A. the book cover
 - B. the character's words and choices
 - C. the page count
 - D. the table of contents
- 2 Setting includes all of the following EXCEPT —
- A. time period
 - B. weather
 - C. place
 - D. narrator's name



Independent Practice (3–5)

Independent • 8 Q's

3

A drama tells its story mainly through —

- A. chapter summaries
- B. dialogue and stage directions
- C. footnotes
- D. captions

5

To analyze how setting shapes a character, a reader should ask —

- A. What does the place force the character to do?
- B. How long is the story?
- C. Who is the publisher?
- D. What is the font size?

4

If a storm delays a rescue, the storm functions as —

- A. a theme
- B. an obstacle in the plot
- C. a stage direction
- D. a definition



Independent Practice (6–8)

Independent • 8 Q's

- 6 A quiet character who speaks up to defend a friend shows —
- A. no change at all
 - B. growth revealed by a plot event
 - C. a change in setting
 - D. a change in genre
- 7 Which detail best shows two characters interacting?
- A. A description of the town square
 - B. A list of the character's hobbies
 - C. One character's advice changing another's plan
 - D. A note about the season
- 8 The climax of a plot is the moment when —
- A. the setting is introduced
 - B. tension reaches its highest point
 - C. the characters are named
 - D. the story is published



Answer Key — Independent Practice

8 Questions

1

B — Words and choices reveal character.

2

D — The narrator's name is not part of setting.

3

B — Drama relies on dialogue and stage directions.

4

B — The storm is an obstacle in the plot.

5

A — It asks how place drives the character's actions.

6

B — Speaking up shows growth revealed by an event.

7

C — Advice that changes a plan is true interaction.

8

B — The climax is the point of highest tension.



Exit Ticket (1–3)

Exit • 5 Q's

1

To analyze means to —

- A. memorize a list
- B. examine parts to understand the whole
- C. read quickly
- D. copy a passage

3

A flooded road that forces a character to walk shows —

- A. setting affecting plot and character
- B. character affecting genre
- C. theme affecting setting
- D. plot affecting spelling

2

Elements that interact —

- A. stay completely separate
- B. affect and change one another
- C. appear only in poems
- D. must be defined first



Exit Ticket (4–5)

Exit • 5 Q's

4

Stage directions are found in a —

- A. dictionary
- B. drama
- C. news report
- D. recipe

5

Which shows a character changing?

- A. She has brown hair in every scene.
- B. She lives in the same town.
- C. She apologizes after refusing to all year.
- D. She owns a red bicycle.



Answer Key — Exit Ticket

5 Questions

1

B — Analyze = examine parts to understand the whole.

2

B — Interacting elements affect and change one another.

3

A — The flood (setting) changes the character's action.

4

B — Stage directions belong to drama.

5

C — The apology shows real change over time.